

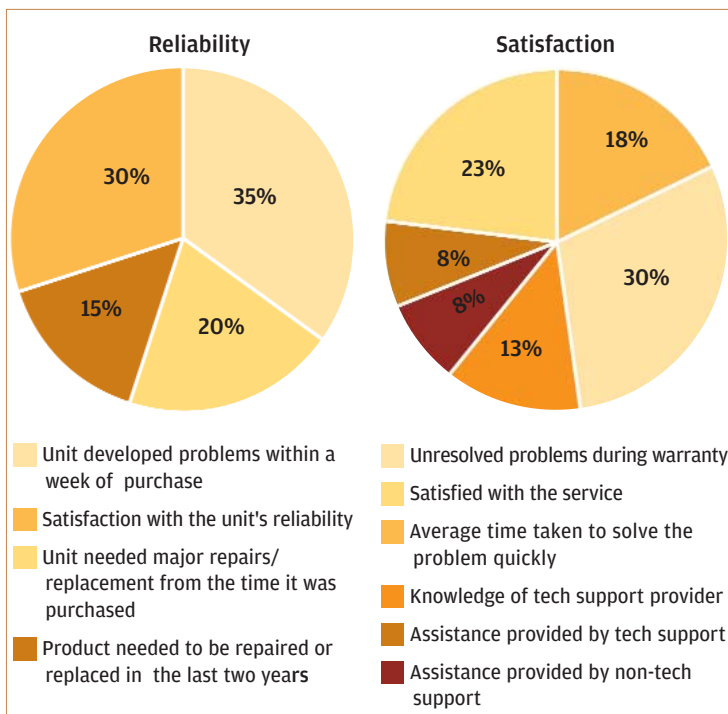
Our Methodology

The 'Icons of Trust' survey interviews were conducted online (through thinkdigit.com) and telephonically. The research sample was taken from the existing reader base of *Digit*, where 2,123 respondents were interviewed. Respondents shared their experiences with about 5.4 products on an average. To maintain a homogenous mix of respondents, people from over 100 cities were chosen to get experiences over the entire geography of India.

Readers were invited to offer their feedback through two

means: by replying to an insert in *Digit* magazine, or by responding to an e-mail request to take the survey. Both methods were tagged with a unique numerical identifier. A respondent would log on to the survey page using this number, and once logged off, the identifier would expire. This ensured that there was no duplication in responses.

All respondents were asked specific questions to gauge their experiences on Reliability and Service satisfaction with a specific product.



Category-wise Weightages		
	Reliability Index	Satisfaction Index
Desktop PC	50	50
Laptop	60	40
Inkjet Printer	50	50
Laser Printer	50	50
Scanner	50	50
CRT Monitor	55	45
HDD	70	30
Optical Disk Drives	50	50
Cell Phone	60	40
Home theatre	50	50
PC Speakers	50	50
UPS	60	40
Digicam	50	50
Portable MP3 Player	50	50

How Was Service Satisfaction Measured?

The total response sample was 2,123, based on which a statistical analysis was conducted to determine, amongst other things, the Reliability and Service indices. To understand the importance given to each question, refer the accompanying pie-charts.

From the Reliability Index and Service Index, an Overall Satisfaction Grade (OSG) was generated for the categories. The grade was meant to indicate how a particular company fared overall, taking reliability and service into consideration, within a sub-category.

To do so, the indices in question were averaged with a weightage in mind: both the Reliability

Cut Out The Middleman

The minimum average time to fix a problem is 6.5 days! Most companies we spoke to claimed service turnaround times of 48 to 72 hours, even in cases where our readers reported an average of three weeks for the same. The common story we heard across companies with good service or bad, is that while they have complete control over the turnaround time within their service network, it's the transit time that turns their speedy service to the time consuming affair it seems to be.

Liteon (average turnaround time: 17 days), for example, claim to offer replacement of their drives for any genuine problem, within two hours. The catch is that you must take the damaged drive to one of their 23 volume partners across India. If you take it to your local retailer, it must be passed up the chain to the distributor who then forwards it to the

regional volume partner, who will then send the replacement back down the same route.

Zenith's (average turnaround time: 22 days) Devita Saraf says that customers across the country send in computers to the retailer for servicing, who must then ship it to the central service station in Navi Mumbai. While the actual servicing takes 48 hours, depending on the choice of delivery method, the transit time could be anything from 48 hours to a week. They claim to do much better on Enterprise services, though, where they handle the service directly rather than through retailers.

The lesson is simple. If you could take a manufacturer's word, you should forget your assembler/retailer and go direct. Call them on their customer support or sales numbers and learn about your service options. Do let us know next year whether that works.